health

Department of
Health
North West Province
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA

WITRAND SPECIALIZED HOSPITAL

COMMUNICATION STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK 2025-2029

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1. INTRODUCTION

1.1. Witrand Hospital Communications strategy sets out the overall framework on how Witrand specialized hospital communications should be managed and how facilitate communications process unfold, while regulating overall Communications, Marketing, and Public Relations efforts, and communications activities during the period covering 2026 to 2029.

This Communications strategy is based on the NW Department of Health Provincial Communications Strategy of 2026 – 2029, and Witrand Hospital Strategic and Operational Plans "Lekgotla" priorities of 2025/2026 and North West Government of National Unity Priorities 2025/2026.

The strategy takes into account all the relevant policies, legislation, and other mandates for which the Communications Unit is responsible. Accurately reflects the strategic outcome-oriented goals and objectives that Witrand Hospital and the Communications Unit will endeavours to achieve over the period 2026- 2029.

Reference to this strategy also encompasses the previous hospital communications strategy and environment in terms of analysis. This Communications strategy accurately planned the implementation of the strategy to reflect the performance targets that the Communications Unit will endeavours to achieve given available resources.

1.1.1. SCOPE & CONTEXT.

Witrand Specialized Hospital's communication strategy is based on the needs of the institution as well as the overall strategic plan for Communications, Public Relations, and Marketing efforts of the hospital while, encompassing communications policy documents for the North West Provincial Department of Health of 2025-2029, and the National Department of Health.

Witrand Specialized Hospital's Communications strategy serves as a basis and framework for the implementation of all communications, Public Relations, and Marketing efforts intended to market the program, services of the hospital, and Media including social media platforms.

The work plans of Witrand specialized hospital communicators corroborate the strategy based on available resources such as the budget 2026/2027 going forward. This includes among other things, the Witrand Specialized Hospital Rebranding, Repositioning and Renewal, the handover of capital projects, innovative and public relations initiatives, and wellness activities which fits well in this context.

Based on the above, collaborative leadership is the most advanced model in terms of behavioural communications and prioritize teamwork and communication. By implementing this strategy, we aim to enhance collaboration, improve patient care quality, and create a positive work environment for healthcare professionals.

Collaboration among various healthcare professionals, including doctors, nurses, pharmacists, and other medical staff, fosters holistic solutions, accelerates decision-making, and enhances patient care quality. Come up with mechanisms that support effective collaboration, including good communication, clear role distribution, and a culture of mutual respect.

The main goal is to inform and educate both the internal and external stakeholders about hospital services in general, while at the same time eradicating and curbing the stigma associated.

Messaging by the institution's management has to be properly cascaded down to all the employees and all the external stakeholders within the hospital's jurisdiction asymmetrically, through the office of the CEO.

2. OBJECTIVES OF THE COMMUNICATION STRATEGIC FRAMEWORK

Public health communication is premised on dissemination of accurate, timely, and relevant health information to diverse populations, aiming to influence positive health behaviors and outcomes as the primary objective.

Moreover, public health education, closely linked to communication, seeks to improve health literacy by equipping individuals and communities with the knowledge and skills needed to make informed decisions.

Awareness campaigns are designed as spotlight to specific health issues, reduce stigma, and encourage preventive measures. Together, these efforts aim to empower people to take control of their health while fostering a more informed and health-conscious society.

2.1. Based on the Departmental Communications Strategy and the Hospital's strategic plan, the objectives of Witrand Hospital communication strategy are as follows:

- To ensure that all stakeholders are better informed, engaged, and able to access information about the hospital, to improve the knowledge and understanding of the overall specialized services of Witrand Hospital.
- To eradicate the stigma associated with psychiatry through different mediums at the hospital's disposal.
- To strengthen media relations, and stakeholder relations, and minimize the general mistrust prevailing among communities towards the hospital.
- To maximize community outreach programs (ensure effective external stakeholder management by enhancing face-to-face communication with internal and external stakeholders with emphasis on Batho Pele Principles, Patients Right Charter, and promotion of healthy lifestyle for all and particularly selling the services of the institution to all external stakeholders in consultation with the hospital board).
- To enhance the corporate identity & and image of the hospital within the area of jurisdiction and throughout the Province.
- To enhance corporate Image and Identity of the Hospital and the department.
- To rebrand and market the hospital, its services, programs, and in-house projects through print and electronic media. To ensure recognisable Witrand Specialized Hospital & Dept of Health brand, consistent messaging on hospital and health information.

- Proactive communications to address expectations before they get voiced as well as good news stories. This way, you strengthen media relations and minimize the general mistrust prevailing among journalists towards health facility managers.
- To ensure effective internal stakeholder management by facilitating the free flow of information to all staff members within the hospital and vice versa through a two-way asymmetric model of communications.
- To ensure effective management of all internal events, campaigns, and exhibitions (e.g. promote a healthy lifestyle, substance abuse, psychiatry, and promotion of rehabilitation units in community and school outreach programs).
- To ensure potential risks are managed proactively to protect the institution's reputation.

2.2. Demand Creation & Media Engagement.

Demand creation involves generating interest and encouraging uptake of health services or interventions, such as New Forensic Psychiatric Services or screenings, especially in communities with historically low engagement.

Media engagement through traditional outlets, social media, and influencers enhances visibility and builds trust with target audiences. By leveraging the power of storytelling, visuals, and tailored messaging, public health practitioners can spark behaviour change, mobilize communities, and sustain long-term health improvements.

Health practitioners can also spark behaviour change by using health promotions and community mobilization. The effective strategies integrate individual focused models like Pender's Health Promotion Model and Social cognitive Theory with broader community based intervention (enabling people to take control of their health through educations, social support, and skill-building).

#Humans learn by observing others (showcase positive role models who already exhibit healthy behaviour to build motivation).
Build self-Efficacy; cultivate confidence in individuals to perform new behaviour by setting achievable, small goals (reinforcement).
#Use of Brief Intervention and motivational interviewing (empathic listening, use of open ended question, help find own motivation etc.)
#Environmental Restructuring; modification of residence place to make healthy choice easier (keeping healthy food visible).

3. ENVIRONMENT

Analysis in terms of the environment shows that mental health disorders are a growing global public health challenge, and disproportionately affect the poor.

Low- and middle-income such as in South Africa and other countries (LMICs) bear 80 % of the mental health disease burden. Stigma associated with mental health results in delayed help-seeking, reduced access to health services, suboptimal treatment, poor outcomes, and an increased risk of individual human rights violations.

Moreover, widespread co-occurrence of physical comorbidities such as non-communicable diseases with mental health disorders makes the treatment of both conditions challenging and worsens prognosis. Our immediate community in the North West Province is also equal to the challenge above. Hence, it is vital to come up with a communications strategy that will also address these challenges.

Witrand Hospital was one of the facilities in Dr Kenneth Kaunda District in the North West Province to benchmark the rollout of vaccine as a site, and the hospital did extremely well in dealing with this new phenomenon. This means we have the necessary requisites to execute any service delivery endeavours, and improve our services as the hospital.

3.1. Explore various communication endeavours towards reducing stigma.

Witrand Specialised Hospital and the entire Dr. Kenneth Kaunda District Health need to explore various communication endeavours towards reducing stigma towards mental health and increasing help-seeking and access to and uptake of mental health services.

Stigma impacts persons living with mental illness, their families and caregivers and healthcare professionals (mental health professionals, non-psychiatric specialists, and general practitioners) imparting mental health care.

It is best then to look at cultural, socio-economic, and religious factors to determine various aspects of mental health in LMICs, ranging from **perceptions** of health and illness, health-seeking behavior, and attitudes of the individuals and health practitioners and mental health systems to determine mental health outcomes.

Addressing stigma requires comprehensive and inclusive mental health communications strategy, health policies, and legislations; sustainable and culturally-adapted awareness programs; capacity building of mental health workforce through task-shifting and inter-professional approaches; and improved access to mental health services by integration with primary healthcare and utilizing existing pathways of care is the best approach.

Going forward, Witrand Specialized Hospital Communications Strategic plan targeting stigma reduction must consider the enormous physical comorbidity burden associated with mental health, prioritize workplace interventions, and importantly, address the deterioration of the population's mental health from the COVID-19 pandemic, and Socio- Economic situations. We therefore, need to employ the above is the means to reduce the stigma associated with mental health.

The Hospital need to make use of publicity, social media and interpersonal Communications more by integrating PR, Marketing, and communications endeavours to achieve our goals.

3.2. Communication with both internal and external.

Communications with both internal and external stakeholders is ongoing. Although, there are challenges in reaching out to external stakeholders and immediately making a robust impact.

The ongoing mood is realized due to one-on-one sessions being done by CEO communications with different categories of staff including MBWAs.

Communications officer and CEO must make sure that there are meetings at a unit level which culminates to unit Imbizo's and eventually the main Imbizo.

Reaching out to external stakeholders of the hospital to change the negative perception associated with Witrand & its ongoing, to further educate them to change their attitude and encourage them to raise their concerns as and when they prevail, could be in person or via different engagement channels.

To change the perception various channels of communications and public relations Mx has been engaged in and continues to improve the communications platforms such as introducing an online help center, developing the new hospital website, etc.

This necessitates us to tap from the move for the Patient's Rights Charter, Batho Pele principles, and access to hospital services to avoid negative publicity by the media and a bad corporate image.

3.3. MEDIA ENVIRONMENT:

Since the prevailing media coverage concern that erupted in the 1st quarters of the 20224/2025, and the two last Quarters of 2025/2026 financial year where negative coverage hit the image of the hospital and with the subsequent establishment of Investigation Commission instituted by MEC For Health Sello Lehari to look into the matter related to demised patient and come up with recommendations.

Communications unit would assist to come up with a communications strategy to change media perception and prioritization mental health care news.

Over the past five years, Witrand Hospital and the entire North West Department of Health have managed to regain a commendable media profile both at Regional, Provincial, and national levels.

Key to this achievement has been the consistent and dedicated work put up by hospital management, communicators, and the provincial communications unit and Health MEC who has always been ready to use media to communicate the key message of the Department.

The media-friendly approach and engagement "policy" have resulted in the Department touching new grounds, especially on the national front with the free-to-air channel E.tv, the public broadcaster SABC, and several other regional commercial radios working very closely with the

Department and hospital. The trend-setting achievements of the hospital and the department have attracted wide media coverage

Despite these positive developments, there is still an element of mistrust between the media and the government. This relates to the different nature, agenda, intentions, and focus of these institutions. Our communications strategy requires to strengthen this strategic means.

3.3.1. Media-wise, the following trends emerge around coverage of facilities, departmental, and government programs in general:

- Less attention is paid to developmental programs of the government by the media.
- Disease outbreaks like COVID-19 and infection control systems, negligence are always a subject of media interest.
- Less skilled journalist who would go to the roots of the problem and write articles covering both sides of the story. At most sensational news coverage is the name of the game.
- Media still focusing too much on the negatives like corruption, political infightings, failures of government, and character assassination.
- While the coverage focused mainly on the above issues, we have however, seen a decline in sensational reporting by some of the journalists and this can be attributed to our continuous engagement and relationship and partnership-building approach with the media.
- The tabloidization of newspapers and the growing commercial approach by broadcast media has made it a challenge for the government to filter through its message using these mediums. This situation has amplified the need for government to aggressively diversify media platforms.
- Social media platforms therefore, present a unique opportunity to promote the Department's programmes, successes, and interventions that are being implemented in tackling the current communication challenges. The use of Departmental Facebook and Twitter pages will be upscale for purposes of marketing health programmes and activities.

  It remains a challenge to assist in empowering journalists to report accurately and on an informed basis. This may mean inviting them to some of the facility / Departmental seminars and conferences. It also means involvement in facility/ Departmental activities which may help generate balanced coverage and build mutually beneficial ties between journalists and the facility/ Department.

3.3.2. Cases of Medical Negligence:

The ongoing media reports on cases of negligence in the department continue to reflect negatively on the state of health care service delivery in the province. The Department has made strides in attempt to address this challenge, however it appears patients have now been orientated to sue the Department at any given opportunity hence there is a significant increase in the number of cases.

This is evident of a growing trend amongst our communities to always run to media houses when they are not satisfied with our services even when they have proposals on how we should improve the provision of health care services in our province. It will therefore, be crucial to proactively communicate any effort or initiative made to address this challenge to minimise the negative reports.

3.3.3 National Health Insurance (NHI):

Although, there is s decision by National government to indefinitely suspend the implementation of NHI. Going forward, the National Health Insurance (NHI); phased-in implementation of the National Health Insurance (NHI) would continue in providing hope to the majority of the health services users. Our country and province is moving in the direction that will see improved access to health care services.

The NHI message that continues to be echoed is that of a health care system that is leaning toward the poor majority of the citizens who will eventually have access to the same care that is accessible even to those who afford the best and quality services there is to offer.

The citizens of North West Province and JB Marks Communities are therefore, beginning to believe that the NHI will promote equity and efficiency to ensure that everyone has access to affordable, quality healthcare services regardless of their socio-economic status.

3.3.4. Ideal Hospital Initiatives:

Our Communications strategy also take cues from the implementation and outcomes of The Ideal Hospital Realisation and Maintenance Framework (IHRM-F), a strategy designed to improve health service delivery, quality of care, and patient experience, particularly in preparation for National Health Insurance (NHI). It focuses on strengthening health systems through efficient, clean, and well-equipped facilities with skilled staff.

The framework provides a checklist of actionable standards to monitor and improve hospital performance, including 24-hour emergency services and appropriate, compassionate care.

3.4. Internal Organization Environment:

There has been noticeable improvement in releasing information to keep staff members informed of developments in the hospital and department.

The initiative of the weekly "News Flash" publication coupled with the monthly internal newsletter, noticeboards update and globalisation of information sharing through group whatsapp and email has improved internal communication.

Yet, Compartments and operation as silos remains the order of the day. Despite traces of shared common vision and mission, reality is that all of us have different approaches and the goals of the unit or section supersede that of the organization which needs to be corrected.

We will continue to take leverage from hospital events and year plan of activities which seem to take our employees out of their cocoon and actively participate in Health and Wellness Activities.

Turfs or protection of personal boundaries remains a defining feature at various level of government. However, there is observed improvement. This situation is further compounded by the growing challenge of communicating with expanded constituency base both internally and externally because of the nature of our clients.

Promoting corporative governance and intergovernmental relations has potential to improve this situation. Improved internal communication at all levels has the potential to deal with low staff morale and dismantle turfs.

4. A COMMUNICATION APPROACH: PRIORITIES OF THE NGU ADMINISTRATION FOR THE 2025 – 2026.

4.1. The North West Department of Health will rally behind the national call to action with the core message of **"Let's Grow North West Together".**

The Department's strategic communication approach and posture should also help rally communities and citizens of the Province around the vision of 2030 as articulated by the National Development Plan (NDP). This will help to divert attention from the despair and complaints about poor health services.

4.1.1. NW Department of Health & NW Province Key Priorities for 2025/2026

Based on the alignment with NW Province Government Priorities for 2025/2026, the NW Department of Health's key priorities for 2025/2026 include:

1. **Accelerated Service Delivery Programme- Thuntsha Lerole:** Improving healthcare service delivery and responsiveness to community needs by ensuring a safe and healthy work environment.

2. **Re Bona Ka matlho:** Implementing executive intervention to address delays and inefficiencies in healthcare services, including improving internal referral systems and employee support programs.

3. **Kopano, ke matla:** Mobilizing key stakeholders, including healthcare professionals, patients, and communities, to prioritize healthcare and wellness.

4. **Tshela ka itekanelo:** Promoting access to healthcare services and encouraging individuals to utilize these services to improve health outcomes.

5. **Mental health is our priority:** Providing psychological support and promoting mental health awareness in healthcare settings and communities.

6. **Caring for people with intellectual disability**: Ensuring inclusive and caring healthcare services for individuals with intellectual disabilities.

These priorities will guide the NW Department of Health's efforts to improve healthcare outcomes, promote wellness, and ensure a safe and supportive work environment for healthcare professionals.

4.1.1.2. NW Provincial Key Strategic Programmes/Priorities and Key Messages for 2025 /2026

1. Accelerated Service Delivery Programme- Thuntsha Lerole.
2. Re Bona Ka matlho – executive intervention to unblock where there is delay in terms of service delivery.
3. Kopano, ke matla. To mobilize key stakeholders
4. Tshela ka itekanelo – encourage access and adequate use of govt services to improve individual and community health.
5. Mental health is our priority
6. Caring for people with intellectual disability

4.2. Hospital governance committees serve as a powerful change management approach.

Hospital governance committees serve as a powerful change management approach by restructuring how decisions are made, elevating accountability, and fostering a culture of continuous improvement. By transitioning from a board-centric model to specialized committee structures (e.g., Health & Wellness committees, quality, finance, safety), hospitals can better manage operational changes, and communications such as digital transformation or the implementation of clinical governance protocols.

The establishment of different health and wellness governance committees such as men forum, religious committee, events committee Quality committee OHS etc. brought about campaigns that also focus on building and maintaining social cohesion through the facility's social cohesion, initiating the Reconciliation, Healing, and Renewal concept, which seeks to facilitate behavioral change and unity in diversity.

Witrand Hospital's organizational culture and staff morale should be elevated as the seamless, and only way of inference for improving our standards and doing the right things right all the time.

4.2.1.1. Corporate image and identity elevated through the ideal hospital model.

In this regard, Witrand Specialized Hospital and the Provincial Dept of Health will consistently communicate and share progress attained in the ideal hospital model.

The ideal hospital model should set the tone in terms of rebranding all facilities and buildings in a way that reflects a caring, healing, and welcoming environment. The communication approach will also be targeted at reversing the negative media reports that have affected the image of the facility structure and department.

Furthermore, the Department stands to benefit from coordinated National, Provincial, and Cluster Communication Plans which will not only strengthen communication but has the potential to also strengthen intergovernmental relations.

5. COMMUNICATION PROGRAMMES AND CAMPAIGNS

5.1. Street name changes project:

Changes are necessary for the brand to grow, and it is within this context that the Witrand hospital board initiated street name changes. This is relevant as the street names are currently worn-out and no longer visible. Hence the new names suggested by staff to be implemented.

5.2. Platforms

- **Quarterly Hospital Internal Newsletter** which is the mouthpiece of the hospital and is published quarterly to inform the internal stakeholders about programs, services, and projects as well as success stories within the hospital. Quarterly reports from the CEO and the hospital board are to be published in the newsletter.
- A separate column for the CEO to communicate with stakeholders also features within the newsletter. Managers and other staff members will also get a chance to use the newsletter as a platform to profile their programs, projects, and success stories.

- **External Informational Newsletter** which is published on a quarterly, and or bi-yearly basis to provide sufficient information to the general public about the Hospital and its processes, at the same time educating and informing all external stakeholders about what management and the board have been up to at the hospital.
- **Service Brochure** is an ongoing production to be available in all the strategic points of the hospital. Information about the services being offered, visiting times, and whom to contact upon compliments or complaints.

5.2.1. Internal Platforms

- Clinical employees portal
- Face-to-face meetings with different internal stakeholders
- **CEO Executive Management and the board visitation to hospital wards** to interact with nurses, clients, and other health professionals
- **Meet the Executive Management** sessions where the CEO meets all staff members in different areas of operation in a one-on-one session.
- **Build up to the main Imbizo** where all units in the Nursing, Corporate, Support, and Clinical to have build-up mini imbizo prior to the main Imbizo
- **General Imbizo for all staff members** where the Senior Management Team and the Hospital Board participate in Imbizo and Roadshows to listen to the concerns raised by people and staff members as part of the hospital's commitment to promoting a reasonable and transparent service delivery

- **Posters and notices** are used as a tool of information beneficial to staff members to be placed on notice boards which are managed by designated officials in respective units. New

notice boards are to be placed in strategic areas of the hospital for information to filter through to all employees.

- **Innovative box** used to encourage the free flow of communication between management and staff members, suggestions and innovative ideas placed on this box for implementation by management.

5.2.2. External Communications Platforms

5.2.2.1. Radio Interviews (weekly health-wise slots)

- Utilizing local and regional radio stations and talk show programs to market the hospital, services and further eradicate the negative perception about mental health (this requires support from line managers in all Directorates) current plan: Gaining FM health slots.
- 2026/2027 official Witrand Hospital Health Radio Slots should be based on different health calendar day topics. The format should form part of the employee's opinion and or suggestions. Radio slots can be a combination of documentaries, drama, live presentations, and advertisements to be presented at Aganang FM as per the attached schedule. NB!!! This is paid content.
- The radio slots enable us to create awareness of mental health and rehabilitation services we provide, and aid in educating and informing communities about the hospital's services while curbing the stigma associated with mental illness.
- In so doing we contribute towards the realization of our vision: A long and healthy life for all communities of the North West Province.
- H.O.D are further requested to be in touch with communications for proper preparations of the script, line of questions, coaching, etc. Communications might engage the hospital presenter and or HODs where there are issues that need to be communicated on different platforms to reach a wider audience such as newspapers, facebook, websites, etc.
- Managers in respective units adhere to the official radio schedule and encourage communities to switch on. We can also do this via internal posters, Facebook page, website, etc.

6. CORPORATE IDENTITY: "WITRAND SPECAILIZED HOSPITAL" AS A BRAND.

- **Corporate Manual:** Witrand Hospital corporate manual must be aligned with the provincial department of health & the NW Provincial corporate manual. All buildings, new units and expansions including renovations must comply with the corporate manual as prescribed to ensure uniformity and uncompromised corporate identity of the hospital.
- *In all IEC material including social media our brand "**Witrand Specialized Hospital**" must definitely not just be aesthetic. We want our brand image to reflect our Image and Identity constantly to our customers and our employees".*

- **Rebranding:** The process of rebranding, especially when you're changing both the name and the entire visual identity, always starts with the fundamentals the who's, the what's, and the whys. So we should go back and started redefining the core of our identity.
- At first, it was just us talking about why we do what we do and what higher purpose it has. And it always came down to one thought: **Witrand Specialised Hospital as a brand.**
- Witrand Specialised Hospital is a straightforward and diverse brand, freshened up with **blue** and **green** colors and a logo, representing our commitment to helping our customers find and understand relevant mental health information to drive better the hospital goals.
- We introduce our new motto, **"How Can I Help You"** which captures our focus on providing reliable and functional onsite service, not just a service and effective hospital mental health, disability & and rehabilitation services.
- The motto: **"How Can I Help You"** singles out our most important responsibility and keeps reminding us of our purpose of coming to work. Moreover, it takes us back to the realization of our vision and mission. That we are only here to serve.
- With the ever-growing surge in online channels and social media usage, our customer's need to monitor their online presence is becoming more present.

6.1. Corporate signage and media toolkit for essential improvements of Image:

- Our visual and media identity (from the main entrance gate to the point of service) enables us to improve the overall customer experience.
- All of our communication channels should be aligned under a common brand identity, ensuring consistency across all touchpoints including media platforms.
- Our product and service should be marketed to the entire community of North West Province and the entire world. This means easy access, a user-friendly hospital that must adapt to the changes, and a clearer interface enabling you to find important information even faster.
- The new brand will enable us to build a stronger bond with our customers and continue supporting them in making sense of the mental health world around them by delivering relevant information from the media in real-time.
- We need to recognize those among us who once worked and left a significant difference in how we see Witrand Specialised Hospital to date.

6.1.1. Signage:

Most of the hospital signage is worn out. Procurement of signage is vital. Mainly the Communications unit should take complete control of signage inventory. Perform regular audits of signage. Keep the corporate manual as a referral for signage. If possible create customized vector artwork automatically. Collaborate with designers and fabrics during rebrands, and creation of IEC materials.

6.2. Electronic Information Disseminators: Website, Intranet & Billboard.

- Electronic information board at the main gate
- Uplift the image of the hospital with contra visions at the main gate and strategic entrances (OPD).
- Submit content for the departmental website regularly and feed the Department's intranet with information to publicize what the hospital had been up to. To produce content and establish an internal link to the hospital intranet that will provide employees with policies, information about the hospital, events, and key messages from management.

6.2.1. **Official Hospital Website**: www.witrandhospital.gov.za information disseminator to all internal and external publics.

Witrand Specialized Hospital website provides you with the opportunity to establish Witrand Specialized Hospital as a brand and advertise the services that we provide. It's also a convenient way to provide contact information for potential customers in the entire North West Province.

Besides creating a site for our hospital services, the hospital may add pages on the Website for specific services we offer. This can allow the hospital a unique focus of our own branding

In all cases, working to improve your search engine optimization and the usability of your pages can increase the performance of your website as marketing material.

Official Hospital Intranet: updated every week with content aimed at staff members; e.g. Policies, protocols, memos and directives from head office and amongst colleagues (GroupWise emails).

N12 Electronic Billboard: These are external signage directing public to the point of services and sharing information about briefly about services and act as a market platforms for the hospital. *Below is See example of Corporate Branding:*

Corporate colors at the Main Gate / Include Contra Visions on the pacifications

100 Year celebration logo for Witrand Specialized Hospital

7. MEDIA & SOCIAL MEDIA

- **Current Hospital page: Witrand specialized hospital on Facebook**
- **WhatsApp Line: Official line**

- Witrand Hospital has a standard operating procedure on handling media and social media. This SOP has to be observed at all times.

- With the shifting of media consumption patterns, new communication platforms are becoming more critical to reach a wider and larger population: this then calls for greater utilization of the social media Facebook, Twitter, etc. stepping out and being part of the digital revolution joining the historical transition that allows conversation and interaction with all stakeholders,

- Visitors, family, and friends of patients we house as well as the overall public rather than simply communicating to them.

- To improve, strengthen and nurture all communications, stakeholders, and public relations efforts improving access to all stakeholders (different audiences) allows the hospital to adjust or refocus communications quickly where necessary increase the speed of constituent feedback and input reaching specific audiences on specific issues reducing the hospital's dependence on traditional media channels to communicate with all stakeholders.

- Creating a Twitter and Instagram account for the hospital that would link with all the online platforms of the hospital.

- Guidelines and communication protocols around the use of social media to be implemented to ensure that the legitimate and authoritative voice of the hospital is not lost.

7.1. Print Media

- **Newspapers and Magazines**: generate articles on topical issues and use them for advertorials and feature stories. Members of the Senior Management Team will be encouraged to write **"opinion pieces"** on various topical issues and use that for columns such as letters to the editors. This could be used as a way of correcting inaccurate reporting.

7.2. Mental Health Hospital Communications Strategy:

- **To foster collaboration and enhance patient care quality, our strategy focuses on:**

1. **Interdisciplinary Teams:** Establish regular meetings and case discussions involving doctors, nurses, pharmacists, and other medical staff to promote shared decision-making and holistic solutions.
2. **Clear Communication Channels:** Implement a standardized communication protocol using digital platforms, email, and face-to-face interactions to ensure seamless information exchange.

3. **Role Clarification:** Define roles and responsibilities to avoid confusion and overlapping tasks, promoting mutual respect and trust.
4. **Collaborative Care Plans:** Develop patient-centered care plans with input from all healthcare professionals, ensuring comprehensive and coordinated care.
5. **Feedback Mechanism:** Establish a feedback loop to encourage open communication, address concerns, and identify areas for improvement.
6. **Training and Education:** Provide regular workshops and training sessions on effective communication, conflict resolution, and teamwork to promote a culture of mutual respect.
7. **Recognition and Rewards**: Recognize and reward collaborative efforts and achievements to reinforce positive behaviors and motivate staff.

7.3. Mechanisms for Effective Collaboration as a Communications means:

1. **Multidisciplinary Meetings:** Regular meetings with clear agendas and action items.
2. **Shared Electronic Health Records:** Ensure all healthcare professionals have access to patient records and can contribute to care plans.
3. **Pharmacist-Led Medication Reviews:** Pharmacists review patient medications and provide recommendations to doctors and nurses.
4. **Nurse-Lied Care Coordination:** Nurses coordinate patient care and communicate with other healthcare professionals.
5. **Peer Support Program:** Pair experienced staff with new or struggling colleagues for support and mentorship.

7.4. Organizational Culture:

1. **Respect and Empathy:** Foster a culture of mutual respect, empathy, and understanding among healthcare professionals.
2. **Open Communication:** Encourage open and transparent communication, where staff feel comfortable sharing concerns or ideas.
3. **Collaborative Leadership:** Leaders model collaborative behaviors and prioritize teamwork and communication.

By implementing this strategy, we aim to enhance collaboration, improve patient care quality, and create a positive work environment for healthcare professionals.

Collaboration among various healthcare professionals, including doctors, nurses, pharmacists, and other medical staff, fosters holistic solutions, accelerates decision-making, and enhances patient care quality. Come up with mechanisms that support effective collaboration, including good communication, clear role distribution, and a culture of mutual respect.

8. MESSAGES AND THEMES.

The North West Department of Health is also rallying behind government's national and provincial theme and core message of "**Unite to make our country stronger and better – leave no one behind**".

Provincial Government theme for 2026 – 2029	**Witrand Specialized Hospital Key Messages 2026 -2029;**
Provincial Government message; # Building NW Province That Works For All.	• Mental health: it is ok not to be ok" • "Champion for the rights of people with mental illnesses" • "Striving for equity in mental health care comparable to other health care, and reducing stigma and discrimination against those with mental illnesses". • "patients centered and oriented service delivery " • "Serious mental health conditions can be treated, however, allowing people to better contribute to their families and communities". • "Transition for better patient care" • "Better, ever-improving specialized health care services" • "Informed concerned citizens make better decisions regarding their specialized health status" • "Working faster, harder, and better"
NW Dept of Health Messages; **Lead Message** # Let's Grow North West Together for Better Health Outcomes **Messages for Re-engineering NHI** # Taking health care back to basics! # Quality health care for all	
Facility: Witrand specialized motto "How can I help you"	

9. TARGET AUDIENCE (Stakeholders' segmentation)

Target Market: From the above objectives, for the communication plan to yield the necessary results, effective market segmentation of the target market is important. Segmentation is informed by the Department's expected outcomes from interacting with all sectors of the community in pursuance of its objectives.

9.1. Audience Segmentation: The audience is categorized into the following distinct segments which are:

- **Local residence:** These are the ordinary citizens that reside in Dr Kenneth Kaunda District and the NW Province. Those in rural communities belong to the LSM 1- 3 and those found mainly in urban areas are probably in LSM 5 – 9. All these needs to be assured and informed of the developments.

- **Patients:** these are a very important audience because they are the ones experience health services at first hand. They therefore are most in need of messages of assurance and information on prevention of diseases, education and awareness from the Department.

- **Stakeholders:** These are people and organizations within and outside the intergovernmental fold that are actively involved in partnership with the department in the facilitation and delivery of health services to the communities. They include faith based organisation, civil society organisations, traditional leadership, the business fraternity, youth formations

- **Government Officials or Departmental Employees:** These are our secondary target. They need to be informed so that they can impart their knowledge and information to our communities. Our staff members should be our eyes and ears on the community and should actively act as our ambassadors.

- **The Media:** the media remain one medium which our communities rely on for information. Once journalists are fed with the right information they are bound to be a useful tool of communication. Anything that the department says or does wittingly or unwittingly it will be in the audience of the media who will publish it hence it is important that what they publish is true.
- **Politicians:** They need targeted information as many of them do not have much accurate health knowledge but are key for delivering information to the communities.

10. MESSENGERS

- MEC
- CEO/authorized Clinical Manager
- Director for Media & Communications (Official Spokesperson of the hospital)
- Chairperson of Hospital Board
- Extended Delegated Manager of the hospital/Programme Managers
- Hospital Communicator/Spokesperson.

11. STRATEGY/ ACTIVITIES & RESPONSIBILITIES

11.1. **Hospital Promotional Material and Publications.**

All promotional Materials; and brochures (any IEC material) will have appropriate branding to enhance the corporate identity and image of the hospital. Communications Unit to review all IEC materials.

- **Marketing collateral that includes amongst other pull-up banners, brochures, boards, lanyards, mugs, calendars, pens, etc.**
- To promote the role of the hospital, its vision and mission, values, and key services as well as programs.
- **Corporate video**: to be produced and played at the outpatient and serve as a basis for selling the hospital and its services (downloaded to YouTube).

- "Witrand Hospital Today": An informational booklet profiling the hospital, leadership, and management of the institution, processes followed to be distributed externally and internally. This booklet can also assist in the induction program of new employees.

11.2. **Media Liaison Activities in Conjunction with Head Office**

Media open days to be arranged for journalists to visit the hospital.

- Media briefings about the hospital
- Hospital tours
- Know your hospital-targeted unit tours for students
- Media alerts and releases to be issued on a regular basis informing media of events, campaigns, and policies that require media attention.

11.3. A Phased Communication Program

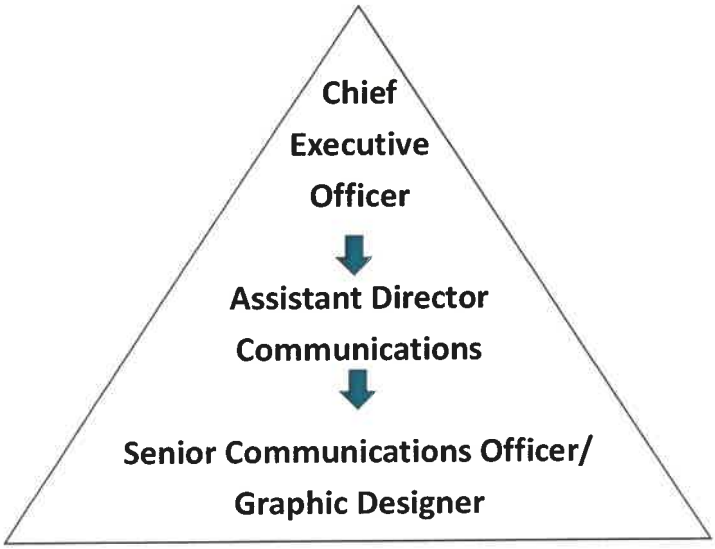
Implementation of communication of some campaigns, programs, and events would take place in phases. In some instances, we would have a preparatory phase followed by an awareness-raising phase, and the actual launching which would be followed by the post-launch phase.

12. COMMUNICATIONS STRUCTURE & PROCESSES

12.1. Structures (line of command)

The CEO's office and communications directorate will be responsible for the implementation, monitoring, and evaluation of this communications strategy. With the current structure and personnel, it will however, not be possible to implement the strategy effectively. There is a need to increase capacity and introduce skills that are currently lacking.

Approved Communications Structure



13. COMMUNICATION TACTICS: IMPLEMENTATION PROGRAMME

Communication	Target Audience	Time Frame	Remarks
a. **Publications** Re a tswelela newsletter	Internal stakeholders	End of March, June, September, and December every year End of March, June, September, and December every year (4 quarterly publications in a year)	Photography, writing, and editing of stories, layout and design, printing and overall production done in-house. Editorial committee to assist with editing and translation of stories to Tswana and Afrikaans
b. Witrand Link	External stakeholders	End of March, June, September, and December every year	Share hospital activities and services

		(4 quarterly publications in a year)	
c. Services Brochure	External stakeholders	Ongoing and readily available upon request	Align to the hospital corporate image / branding
d. Corporate Items and In-House Publications : Other marketing collateral	Internal and external stakeholders	Yearly procurement plans based on demand plans	Calendars, diaries, pens, mugs, T-shirts Uniformity in internal, and external signage, external way-finding signs, and contra vision at main doors to communicate the requirements of various wards.
e. Strengthening of communication efforts through internal communications channels: Notices, meetings, staff forums, events, suggestions, schemes and publications.	Internal	Ongoing Bi yearly Imbizo March 2026, January 2026, July 2026, February 2027 following month, July 2027, February 2028	CEO's engagements with all stakeholders, internally and externally through different channels are ongoing and improved where there are gaps.
f. External communications and Public Relations Efforts:	External	Annual stakeholder engagement meeting: February 2026 February 2027 March 2028 March 2029	Annual engagement stakeholder meeting with all the hospital stakeholders
g. External engagements		June 2026, October 2026 April 2027 / October 2027 and ongoing	Hospital engagement with parents and friends' association of the patients within the hospital

h. Stakeholder engagements, publications	External	Outreach to the community: Schools, Churches, Clinics, Adopt a Ward. June 2026-2027 Sept 2026/2027 Support Clinical Outreaches to clinics. Ward Based meetings	Support program managers' outreach to communities: Schools etc. Attend regular council & or ward based meetings

13.1 COMMUNICATION TACTICS: IMPLEMENTATION PROGRAMME

MEASURABLE OBJECTIVES	INDICATOR PERFORMANCE MEASURE	ENVISAGED OUTPUT
13.1.1Robust marketing of hospital services and programs • Facilitate social media guidelines & policies • Nurturing of the official hospital social media accounts (Website, Facebook & Twitter)	Number of plans, strategies, number of reports on post frequency topics, events, on the timeline questions/feedback posted by members and downloaded Video. Roadshow about SOP on Social Media and POPI Act. Weekly updates	1 annual strategy and plan 12 reports annually on the post frequency, topics, events, and questions/feedback posted by members and downloaded photos and videos reported at the monthly reviews. Understand the implications and correct use of media & social media. User friendly and helpful media content for decision making.
13.1.2. Market the hospital services: • Radio Plan.	Number of additional radio slots in mainstream media.	Minimum 10 radio slots.

• Marketing of Programs and projects. • Maintenance and updating of the institutional website & intranet facilitate the institution's	Number of projects: publications, newspaper clips, print advertorials. Number of updates on internal resource website.	Issue Advertorials according to projects. 1 annual report.
13.1.3. Maximize community outreach in consultation with the Clinical depts, OPD and Events Committee etc.	Number of events/ Outreach undertaken	4 event /Outreach per quarter
13.1.5. Enhance the Corporate image and identity of the hospital with a main focus on c rebranding the hospital Signage	Number of corporate image and identity analysis reports Re-branding the hospital and the correct usage of the logo and corporate colour. Procurement and correct usage of the branding material and signage	1 Annually Reports Signage audit report / availability of signage Reports and procured Items
13.1.6. Production of the hospital's corporate website, and video focusing on the successes of the hospital.	Availability of website & Host number of corporate videos produced	One annual report with pre and post-production schedule and timeliness
13.1.7 Initiation of Adopt a Ward /Child Initiative.	A number of Wards adopted partnerships with business stakeholders	One annual report and 4 collaborative initiative done
13.1.8. Changing the internal street names	Activity plan produced	One post-event analysis report
1.1.9. Support the hospital programs in the multimedia projects	Number of multimedia projects undertaken	4 project quarterly

14 MONITORING & EVALUATION PROCESSES.

This is the processes set up by the hospital with the goal of improving their communications management outputs, outcomes and impact.

- The implementation of the Hospital Communications Strategy will be periodically appraise to check if we are in line with the hospital strategy and priorities.
- Progress on implementation will be reported at Monthly and during Top Management Meetings, monthly reviews, and weekly engagements with the CEO.
- The metric systems below will be used to monitor the success and effectiveness of the overall activities.
- We will periodically do the internal communications audits.
- Evidence that marketing, Public Relations, and Communication Plans are included in all major projects and services.
- Media monitoring
- Website and intranet hits.
- Social media Updates: likes, shares, engagements, etc.
- Stakeholder engagement Activities: Evidence in partnership participation.
- Adherence and consistent use of corporate identity manual.
- Public perception audits.
- Work performed within available annual allocated budget.

14.1 Key performance indicators:

- Improved stakeholder relations, and target audience knowledge and information on mental health and intervention programmes.
- Improved coordination of campaigns and awareness events in the fourth month of implementation.
- Weekly media planning and monitoring reports.
- Reduced negative media reports (by 15% in 4 months of implementation,40% annually).
- Weekly community radio coverage.
- Weekly staff update both at the employee workspaces and entire hospital through notices, circulars and meetings.
- Availability of adequate resources, with 1 – 5% of the institutional budget allocated to the communication function as per government policy
- Compliance and usage of corporate identity in campaigns & material production.

15. CONCLUSION

Witrand Specialized Hospital is in the process of Rebranding, Repositioning, and Renewing the institutional brand. As we implement our communications strategic plan, we aim to achieve our goals as envisaged during the 2026/2027 and ultimate 2028/2029 financial years, where enormous interventions aimed at uplifting and nurturing the corporate image and identity of the hospital will be engaged upon.

At the same time continuing with the much-anticipated transition of creating "Witrand Specialized Hospital" a formidable mental health brand that is easily accessible and competes with Private Health care regarding the provision of services.

Where there is a transition either of services or processes, awareness to staff members about change in general, decisions of management in a proactive manner is equally important. In terms of the hospital communications strategy, the internal stakeholders' engagement remains the cornerstone of every succeeding institution.

Employees as our hospital ambassadors, naturally, it would be important to communicate with all internal stakeholders about the processes and added services to nurture knowledgeable brand ambassadors.

Our client remains the center of our focus in our everyday provision of quality services. Hence our communications strategic plan focus on "uncompromised patient-oriented services".

External stakeholders in the form of partner organizations/businesses, friends and family members of our patients, and community members at large should also be prioritized in re-affirming the hospital's stand as "an excellent brand with regards to specialized patient care".

While re-affirming our consistent practice of the Batho Pele Principles, and Patients Right Charter to our clients, we must at the same time inform them about the processes, the importance of being involved and how they should help us in helping them to offer efficient specialized health care services.

In essence, the hospital continues to be proactive, creative, accessible, and reliable in disseminating information through various overall communication methods with joint community sessions, hospital board and other stakeholders' engagement.

Lastly, in our communications endeavours, it is also critical to guard against mixed feelings from the community and those that are within the hospital's footprint and eradicate negative perceptions about psychiatry, intellectual disabilities services, the hospital, and its services. We should always be proactive and share good news with public. **End**

WITRAND HOSPITAL

SIGNATORIES

WITRAND SPECIALIZED HOSPITAL COMMUNICATIONS STRATEGY 2026/2027 TO 2028/2029

SUBMITTED BY:

MR N.R. MASIU
AD: COMMUNICATIONS & STAKEHOLDER RELATIONS
WITRAND SPECIALIZED HOSPITAL **DATE:** 24/03/2026

APPROVED / NOT APPROVED

DR. I.Z. WANA
ACTING CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER
WITRAND SPECIALIZED HOSPITAL **DATE:** 24/3/2026

NEXT REVIEW DATE: SEPTEMBER 2029